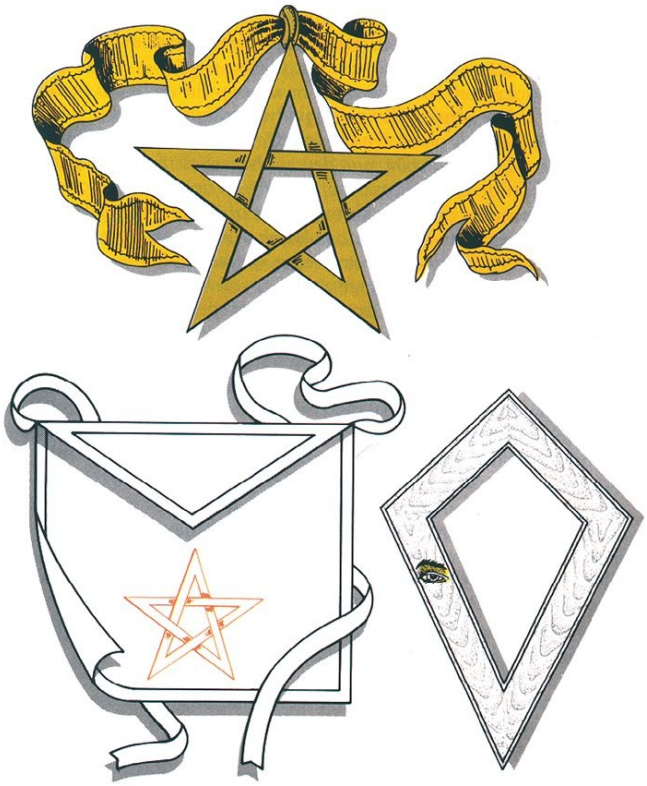
The 27th Degree – Knight of the Sun, or Prince Adept



The apron is of pure white lambskin and has no edging or pattern except the interlaced pentagram, which is traced in the middle in vermilion.

There are three jewels. The presiding officer wears a jewel that is a representation of the sun in gold, suspended by a chain of gold and worn around the neck. The reverse is a hemisphere of gold showing the northern half of the ecliptic and zodiac, with the signs from Taurus to Libra inclusive. The other officers wear a jewel composed of a simple seven–pointed star of gold. The remaining members of the Council wear a jewel that is a gold five–pointed star. Only the jewel of the degree is shown in the illustration.

The order is a broad white watered ribbon worn as a collar. On the right side is painted an eye of gold, a symbol of the sun or of the Deity.

DUTIES

Be a lover of wisdom.
Be faithful to the promises you made within Masonry.

LESSONS

Nature reveals a power and wisdom and continually points to God.
The visible is the manifestation of the invisible.
In the universe two opposite forces provide balance. There is no death, only change.
The moral code of Masonry is more extensive than that of philosophy.

FOR REFLECTION

What can the Book of Nature teach me?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Rebis, Seal of Solomon, Right Triangle, Pythagorean Tetractys.

It should be noted from the outset that this degree is conferred as the Twenty–eighth Degree in many jurisdictions, as it was previously in the Southern Jurisdiction prior to the adoption of the Revised Standard Pike Ritual. The reversal in order was made to give a greater coherence to the system as a whole by allowing the chivalric degrees to be conferred in a more logical and natural order. This slight alteration helps candidates appreciate the lessons in a progressive manner.

The Older Pike Ritual:

CEREMONY

The furnishings in the Council of the Knights of the Sun are few. The seating for the officers is of no particular type. The altar is square. The walls or hangings are painted to represent the open country, mountains, field, forests and plains; that is, *nature.* The ceiling should be decorated to represent the heavens with the moon, the principal planets and the constellations Taurus and Orion. A single powerful light, a great globe of glass, representing the sun, is in the South.

Transparencies throughout the room provide additional light and have upon them the major symbols which are intended to help convey the teachings of the degree. In a physical sense the greater light comes from the sun and the transparencies provide lesser light; symbolically, the sun or great light is the Truth and the lesser lights are man's symbolic representation of Truth.

The most elaborate transparency hangs in the North and may be called the Ancient of Days. The first notable symbol in this complex transparency is its border: the Gnostic *worm ouroboros*, which is a simplified dragon or serpent biting its tail; it is symbolic of all cyclic processes and in particular, of time. The ritual says that

> *the Active Principle seeks the Passive Principle; fullness, is amorous of the void; the serpent's mouth attracts his tail, and revolving on himself, he at the same time flees from and pursues himself.*



We find another explanation in the lecture for the Rose Croix Degree:

> *The serpent... the Phoenicians... deemed to be immortal... becoming young ... by entering into and consuming himself. Hence the Serpent in a circle, holding his tail in his mouth, was an emblem of eternity* (p. 278)*;*

and further in the lecture of this degree:

> *There is a Life-Principle of the world, a universal agent, wherein are two natures and a double current, of love and wrath. ...It is a ray detached from the glory of the Sun,.... It is the body of the Holy Spirit, the universal Agent, the Serpent devouring his own tail* (p. 734).

The figure of an aged man and his reflection reminds us of the Hermetic teachings:

The Visible is the manifestation of the Invisible

and

What is above is like what is below

This concept is first taught in the Scottish Rite system in the Fellowcraft Degree and may be found in its lecture (p. 34). Under close scrutiny, we see the Seal of Solomon as the controlling design motif in the Ancient of Days illustration. It teaches us that the reflection of the Deity is always visible in nature but that we may mistake the shadow for the substance. Thus, to Pike, science was not merely the observation of the physical world that we might understand it, but the study of nature that we might understand *Him*. This is what is meant when Pike says in the lecture, “Even to the Barbarian, nature reveals a mighty power and a wondrous wisdom, and continually points to God” (p. 713) Suspended in the East is a transparency of the Seal of Solomon, which is two interlaced triangles, one white and one black, representing the Macrocosm:



In the center are two Phoenician letters corresponding to ‘Y’ and ‘H’ in English. They are the first two letters of the Ineffable Name of Deity revered by the Hebrews and expressed in the Kabbalah as the Tetragrammaton; commonly written in English as ‘Yahweh.’ It is not until the lecture for the 32nd Degree that

Pike explains the Masonic significance of the Seal of Solomon as a symbol of the Macrocosm:

> *Measure a corner of the Creation, and multiply that space in proportional progression, and the entire Infinite will multiply its circles filled with universes, which will pass in proportional segments between the ideal and elongating branches of your Compass. Now suppose that from any point whatever of the Infinite above you a hand holds another Compass or a Square, the lines of the Celestial triangle will necessarily meet those of the Compass of Science, to form the Mysterious Star of Solomon* (p. 841).

The point here is simply that the Square and Compasses of the Symbolic Lodge may be interpreted in a Kabbalistic way to represent the Macrocosm, or cosmos. The contrasting colors, white and black, represent the duality of the universe as understood by the ancients. This conception of the universe as a duality found its way into Christianity and is now an integral part of the religious philosophy of Freemasonry in general, as well as the rest of the Western world. It is expressed in our Symbolic Lodges by the checkered pavement which represents the ground floor of King Solomon's Temple.

Above the symbol of the Macrocosm, in Latin, is *Lux E Tenebris*, in gilded letters; this phrase comes from the title of a prophetic Rosicrucian work first published in 1657 (*Lux in Tenebris*, 'Light in Darkness') and, as Pike has written it, means simply 'Light out of Darkness.'

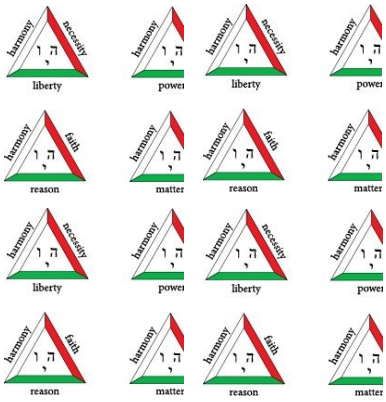
In the West is a transparency of a pentagram, the symbol of the Microcosm, the universe where humans dwell. Since the pentagon which encloses the pentagram may be formed by connecting the five points of the human body, for many centuries this symbol was also used to represent humanity in general.



Other important symbols include four equilateral triangles with sides of white, red and green; one suspended in each corner of the Council Chamber. We have seen the triangle as a symbol of Deity many times in our review of the symbolism of the Scottish Rite Degrees. Here its meaning is expanded to include the concept of the trinity as revealed in the world's religions and occult systems: to the alchemists nature was one but composed of the animal, mineral and vegetable kingdoms; to the Kabbalists the *Sephiroth of Justice* (*Geburah*) when combined with that of Mercy (*Khased*) gives Harmony (*Tephareth*) ; and for the Mason there are the supports of the lodge Wisdom, Strength and Beauty which are expressed in the virtues of faith and reason which, applied in their proper proportion in life, create harmony.

The letters inside each triangle are *Yod*, *He* and *Vau*, the three letters which are used to form the Ineffable Name of Deity, the *He* being repeated at the end. They represent respectively the active, passive and product illustrated by the Pythagorean right triangle. Pike says in the lecture for this degree:

> *The union of the Monad and Duad produces the Triad, signifying the world formed by the creative principle out of matter. Pythagoras represented the world by the right-angled triangle, in which the squares of the two shortest sides are equal, added together, to the square of the longest one; as the world, as formed, is equal to the creative cause, and matter clothed with form* (p. 631).



The sides of the triangles that are white all represent Harmony; the red sides are Necessity, Faith, Wisdom and Spirit; the green sides are Liberty, Reason, Power

and Matter. Shown on the next page are four examples of Masonic triads; these illustrate the concept of equilibrium or balance taught in this degree.

In addition to the presiding officer and one warden, called respectively Father Adam and Brother Truth, there are seven officers. They are named after the seven great archangels in the Kabbalah. Each officer wears a seven-pointed star and a bracelet of one of the seven metals associated with one of the seven planets then known to the ancients. Seven is a sacred number in all symbolic systems. Because it is composed of 3 and 4, it is the magical power in full force, the spirit assisted by the elementary powers, the soul served by nature. The four liberty cardinal virtues: temperance, reason fortitude, prudence and justice; and the three theological virtues: faith, hope and charity, were each associated by the ancients with one of the seven planets.

The officers have square banners of different colors; each is decorated with the zodiacal sign of the associated planet. The four located in each of the four corners of the room, in addition to the zodiacal sign, have a figure on them; the figures are a man, a bull, a lion and an eagle. The associations among the seven officers, the banners, the planets, colors and metals are shown in the following table:

LOCATION	ARCHANGEL	PLANET	VIRTUE/VICE	METAL	COLOR	FIGURE
South	Hanael	Venus	Charity/Luxury	Copper	Blue	—
West	Tsaphiel	Moon	Hope/Avarice	Silver	White	—
East	Zarakhiel	Sun	Faith/Confidence	Gold	Purple	—
Northwest	Raphael	Mercury	Prudence/Indolence	Mercury	Green	Man
Southwest	Auriel	Mars	Fortitude/Rage	Iron	Flame	Bull
Southeast	Michael	Saturn	Temperance/Gluttony	Lead	Black	Lion
Northeast	Gabriel	Jupiter	Justice/Envy	Tin	Crimson	Eagle

The associations summarized in this chart demonstrate the mingling of Kabbalistic and Hermetic philosophy in the ritual. The figures allude to the fourfold composition of the Sphinx. As the Sphinx of mythology did not destroy those who could answer the riddle she posed, those who can acquire the wisdom necessary to understand the nature of man, the Deity and man’s relationship with Him will obtain immortality.

Father Adam, the presiding officer, sits in the East behind Zarakhiel, the angel of the sun. Since Adam was the name of the first man, he is representative of the whole of the human race, the masculine and the active principal; that is, the generative force of nature. The word Adam is derived from the Hebrew word *adama*, meaning earth. Father is a title symbolic of the power of dominion and also of consciousness. The words Father and Adam in combination lead to the interpretation that the dominion of man is the earth, from which Adam was taken, the physical existence of which he is aware. His location in the Council, in the East—source of light—leads us to understand the meaning of the symbolism of the East as the direction representing Deity and the belief that man is a shadow of the Divine.

Brother Truth, the sole warden of the Council, sits in the West near the angel associated with the moon. As the moon is the reflection of the light from the sun, Truth is a reflection of the Deity. The title Masons apply to one another, *brother*, infers not only common participation but the joining at one altar the men of all religions by a common purpose and united by a mutual covenant or tie. Hence Masonry has often been referred to as the Mystic Tie. The notable nineteenth century poet Robert Burns used the phrase in his intended farewell to his Masonic brothers:

Adieu! a heart-warm, fond adieu!
Dear Brothers of the mystic tie!
Ye favored, ye enlightened few,
Companions of my social joy!

We may well ask what in Masonry is the mystic tie? In all of Masonry that common purpose is to discover truth; thus, the mystic tie is the quest for truth, represented in this degree as Brother Truth.

Prior to entering the Council room, the candidate must affirm his willingness to overcome his prejudices with reason so that he might listen, with reverence, to the lessons of the sages. As a reminder of the compelling duty of brotherhood, he is asked if he is willing to carve the favors done for him in marble and the

injuries done to him upon the sand. At the points of two swords and in darkness, he is told that man blindfolds himself; men create their own bondage and enchain themselves. One who is no longer the slave of his passions or his weaknesses may become both a King and a Priest.

To reveal the great secrets of both science and truth to one who is in darkness, bound by his own chains, is like showing the light to birds of the night. The effect is to conceal it since the light blinds them and is darker to them than darkness.

Thus cautioned to maintain an open mind, the candidate is escorted to each of the seven Houses of the Planets to receive instruction, all of which is in the form of brief statements relating a blend of Kabbalistic and Hermetic philosophical ideas.

Hamaliel, in the House of Venus, speaks of duality. Two opposite forces provide balance in the universe, one which attracts and one which resists; they are antagonistic to each other, but not hostile. Man, too, is a duality, composed of spirit and of matter, two contraries producing harmony. In the moral domain are two forces, one which attempts and one which restrains. According to the Kabbalah, both justice and mercy, infinite and perfect opposites, are in God; each makes the other seem impossible, yet from them come harmony.

In the House of the Moon, Tsaphiel states the dogma of the Magi: one in three and three in one, what is above resembles what is below. The word which expresses their resemblance makes three: active and passive join to form unity. Change is the evidence of movement and movement reveals life. The decomposition of the body is the result of the atoms composing the body moving to free themselves. The sages of antiquity possessed this knowledge and did not fear death. They recognized that all men were the authors of their own destinies, making themselves rational and good, and therefore, immortal. Issuing forth from the invisible is the visible which is simply a manifestation of the invisible.

Zarakhiel, archangel of the sun, talks of God, reason, faith and revelation. The permanent revelation is one and universal; it is visible nature. Reason begins the explanation of nature which faith completes. Neither reason nor faith alone is

sufficient to explain nature. Reason, faith and the revelation of nature combine to form one true religion. Faith, inseparable from hope and charity, is simply rational confidence in the unity of reason, for by reason we are assured we will know hereafter what we do not now know.

Raphael, in the House of Mercury, says that causes are revealed by effects. Nature, which is a Book of God, is the effect and God is the cause. Because of the effects, with analogy we may understand the cause and so find the unknown secrets of the effects. Reality is but a portion of the ideal and is comprehensible by the soul. Since there is no void in nature, there is no real death, for death would create a void that is not and could not be.

In the House of Mars, Auriel teaches us that harmony is in equilibrium; we explain its existence by the analogy of contraries. Life and death are contraries but the universe in equilibrium has neither life nor death but only change. Therefore, the man who says he loves life fails to understand the nature of the universe and the man who has overcome the love of life thus overcomes the fear of death.

Michael, in the House of Saturn, tells us the soul of man is immortal and his present life is but a point in the center of eternity. The eternal aspect by generation, decay and regeneration of nature teaches us that man, as a part of nature, also lives on. The spiritual part of man, the soul, is man’s share of the eternal spirit and so is also immortal. Man’s knowledge is, at least largely, limited by his senses. Just as we judge a man’s character by his actions, we understand the harmony of God by its reflection in the harmony of the universe.

Gabriel is the chief of the archangels and from the House of Jupiter, he summarizes the principles of science expressed in the other Houses of the Planets. Science here is the search for truth in all its manifestations and is not limited to a specialized study of the physical world, such as biology or chemistry. All that Gabriel says envelops the great Truth that there is but one God, uncreated, eternal, infinite and inaccessible. Reason and faith unite by analogy. Analogy is the key to all the secrets of nature, themselves the work of God which express His thought and His being.

After taking the obligation of a Knight of the Sun and receiving the jewel, collar, signs, token and words for the degree, the candidate receives additional instruction. Father Adam, the representative of the earthly dominion of man, argues that the only knowledge worth learning is that which relates to the phenomena of nature because nature is God's revelation known to man by his senses. He continues his argument, asserting that the great philosophers, and even the Kabbalah, are for the most part nonsense because they discuss unknown causes of effects not recognizable by the senses. In view of the symbolism and previous lectures in the ritual, we are faced with an apparent contradiction. We do not expect Father Adam, who sits in the East, to tell us that the Kabbalah is nonsense. Father Adam advises the candidate that he may profit from reading the *Legenda*.

The next instruction is from the Great Archangel Gabriel. The Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite fulfills the functions of both King and Priest for its duty is to teach truth in all its varied aspects- moral, political, philosophical and religious. It labors for the good of men and their improvement, for freedom of action, of conscience and of speech. Finally, in apparent contradiction with the words of Father Adam, Gabriel tells us that this degree is chiefly derived from the Kabbalah and again invites us to study both the *Legenda* and *Morals and Dogma*.

The lectures of Father Adam and the Archangel Gabriel demonstrate two different points of view. The lecture of Father Adam is limited to the scope of earthly matters. We, therefore, find Father Adam denigrating the Kabbalah because, being of a purely earthly nature, he cannot understand the spiritual approach to knowledge. For this same reason, his lecture is placed first; only after learning of the earthly world, do we receive instruction on the spiritual. Gabriel, the Great Archangel, is mentioned often in both the Old and New Testament as well as in Apocryphal writings. From these numerous references, we learn that Gabriel gives understanding and wisdom (Daniel 9:22), that he sits at the left hand of God (2 Enoch 24:1) , and that he is the primary intercessor between man and the Deity (1 Enoch 9:1 and 40:6, 2 Enoch 21:3). Of note, too,

is that Islam characterizes Gabriel as the Spirit of Truth. The Archangel Gabriel understands the spiritual approach to knowledge and sees the Kabbalah as worthy of study. The *Legenda* and *Morals and Dogma* present, with great detail, the Kabbalistic and Hermetic doctrines to answer the great philosophical questions concerning the Deity, man and the Deity's relationship to man.

In closing, Brother Truth gives the final lesson:

Riches pass away like shadows on the water;
They are the most inconstant of friends.
Those that are dear to us die;
And our friendships are not immortal.
All men stand upon the margins of their graves;
And one thing alone is beyond the reach of Fate;
The judgment that is passed upon the dead.

Here is an echo from the instruction of the 19th Degree: what we do lives on by its influence on other men.

The Council of Knights of the Sun end their labors at the hours of seven and ten. Seven has past, but ten has not yet come. Seven, as previously discussed, was a much revered number among the ancients, including within itself all that is perfect in the spiritual and earthly realms. The number ten was also imbued with meaning; it is the measure of everything, containing all the numerical and harmonic relations and all the properties of the numbers that precede it. To the sages it was the sign of peace, concord and love; and Pike tells us, "To Masons it is a sign of union and good faith" (p. 638). Since, in this Council, ten has not yet arrived and labors in the world must continue, the number is both a statement of the Mason's hope of union and good faith in the world and a hint of the teachings of future degrees.

LECTURE

The introductory paragraph in *Morals and Dogma* summarizes the purpose of this lecture:

This Degree is both philosophical and moral. While it teaches the necessity of reformation as well as repentance, as a means of obtaining mercy and forgiveness, it is also devoted to an explanation of the symbols of Masonry; and especially to those which are connected with the ancient and universal legend, of which that of Khir–Om Abi [Hiram Abif] is but a variation; that legend which, representing a murder or a death, and a restoration to life, by a drama in which figure Osiris, Isis and Horus, ... and many another representative of the active and passive Powers of Nature, taught the Initiates in the Mysteries that the rule of Evil and Darkness is but temporary, and that that of Light and Good will be eternal (p. 435).

To elaborate the teachings of this degree, four general topics are discussed in great detail: the soul, the heavens, the serpent and symbolism. The discussions are not limited to the Islamic perspective but include a vast range of cultures for the purpose of showing a common thread among the religious and philosophical ideas of the ancients.

The soul and the heavens were closely linked in the minds of the ancients because they believed the soul originated in the heavens, descending upon birth and ascending upon death through the stars. The serpent in the night sky is called the constellation Scorpio and was thought by them to be along the path followed by souls in their descent to earth. So, the serpent became a symbol of malevolence; in the night sky Scorpio ushers in the period of darkness at the autumnal equinox. The serpent was also a symbol of eternity and immortality because in shedding its skin, it was thought to renew its youth.

Since the purpose of the initiations was to purify the soul and impart to man hope for a future life and because the heavens were looked upon with awe by the ancients, the paths of the stars and planets were imparted with a great deal of symbolic meaning. In time the wonder about the heavens became, among the profane, a worship of the heavens. Their corruption of the symbol for the thing symbolized should not be viewed with disdain. Understanding human nature, we should look upon the confounding of symbols with charity, studying their

ancient knowledge in order to formulate our own convictions about the soul, the Deity, and truth. The wonderings of the ancients, particularly the Babylonian Magi, about the night sky were indeed the first religion and the first philosophy. Their exacting calculations and observations established the saros, the cycle of solar eclipses, and removed from the hearts of the populace the most unimaginable terrors. That such knowledge became corrupted and occasionally even became an instrument of political and religious repression only serves to demonstrate how little man has changed over the centuries, first gaining a pure knowledge and then corrupting its use for base ends.

The Revised Standard Pike Ritual:

Bodies of this degree are styled a Council of a Choir of Angels. The Degree teaches candidates about the nature of symbolism; it shows what symbols are, and how to read them. Symbols are used because many abstract, philosophical and profound truths and realizations cannot be expressed by words alone. In the past Degrees you learned something of the ancient mysteries, and were provided with an esoteric interpretation of the Master's Degree. The divine origin and nature of the Self has also been alluded to. You have been introduced to the Kabbalistic philosophy of the Hebrews, and were shown methods by which the ancient initiate investigated the nature of the universe. You are given to understand that the accumulation of knowledge is gradual. It builds upon itself with unceasing labor. It requires great patience and determination. In this Degree you are admonished not to confuse the symbol for the thing symbolized, a practice which leads to confusion and folly. You are also informed that it is the nature of a symbol to both conceal and reveal information. *Revelare*, the word in Latin, means to veil anew.

You are taught that you must emulate Nature in your efforts to digest what you learn. Everything in Nature follows a great cycle. All living things, after fulfilling the measure of their creation, return to the earth only become part of a new form of life. To express this in the symbolism of Alchemy, you must "analyze and synthesize." That is, you must be able to take apart what you have

learned, and put it together in new and useful ways. That which was alluded to in the Eighteenth Degree, you will hear clearly spoken: those who can read the symbols of the Book of Nature are truly Princes among Masons and Adepts among Men.

CEREMONY

This Degree differs from those previously witnessed. The others represented Lodges or Chapters that related stories from history or mythology. But here the candidate sees represented a choir of angels, presided over by Father Adam. A choir of angels is continually active and requires no formal opening or closing because their wisdom, understanding and knowledge is from eternity, without beginning or end.

The ancient adepts gave to Masonry this Degree, and it contains what later adepts supposed their teachings to mean. Even what these have written is obscure, and the interpretation often needs to be interpreted. You have already heard somewhat that they have uttered as oracles of the truth. You are aware that these sayings are so wholly beyond the common fields of thought and speculation, that to understand them it is by no means enough to hear them read. But, one must have the opportunity to study them with diligence, and force them to give up to him their secret meanings.

From ancient times man believed in spiritual beings whose knowledge and insight far exceeded his own. Traditionally, knowledge was seen as their special province, and its dispensation to mankind was their special gift. You will recall that, in Charles Dickens' story, *A Christmas Carol*, the ghosts of Christmas Past, Present, and Future brought knowledge and insight to Ebenezer Scrooge, which changed his entire life.

This Degree may provide a far more profound experience. If you give serious thought to and reflect upon the teachings of this Degree, you will gain insights and knowledge that will change your entire life. Rather than the ghosts of Christmas, you will here see representations of seven angels, clothed with light, who will impart the keys to understanding some of the great mysteries of the

ages. These seven agents are called, in the Hebrew Bible, the *malakoth,* which means “messengers.”

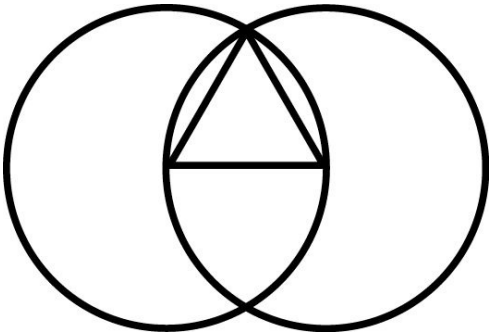
Adam presents himself to the class and explains that his purpose is to expound the nature of symbolism. In brief, a symbol is a representative of something else or, as it says in the ritual, the function of a symbol “is to transform something into something else.” A doctrine ascribed to Hermes, the messenger of the gods, is often expressed in the words “As above, so below.” This means that the material world and all it contains is a pale reflection of the spiritual world above. By analogy, a symbol is a pale reflection of the thing it symbolizes. If we lift one hand toward heaven, and with the other point to the earth, the gesture explains the double Masonic triangle. God, in giving man reason, has given him His Word; and revelation, manifold in its forms, but one in its principle, is contained in its entirety in the universe, by which we know the Absolute Reason. It is the utterance of the Word, which is as universal as itself.

We are all surrounded by symbols, and you no doubt remember those of the Symbolic Degrees of Masonry, and the explanations given of them in each Degree. So far as ours have not been explained, we are given such hints only as may enable us by study and reflection to understand them; and you may then, by diligent study, attain a knowledge of the true meaning of those of the first three Degrees.

Freemasonry has been defined as a beautiful system of morality, veiled in allegory and illustrated by symbols. Indeed, the superiority of Freemasonry over every other order and association, consists chiefly in its symbols. Throughout our Masonic experiences we have encountered many symbols: some were explained, others were not. All of the explanations you received were necessarily incomplete, for the symbol conceals. Some may think it strange that Freemasonry waited this long in the Masonic career to explain the process of interpreting symbols; but the acquisition of knowledge is gradual. It will be easier for you to understand this process since you have seen the preceding degrees. It will be necessary to return to many familiar symbols so that with your new knowledge a deeper understanding may be achieved. Such is the nature of

symbolism that each time a symbol is revisited, its revelations will be more profound. The seven *malakoth* make their appearances and each provides a brief lecture on some aspect of symbolism.

Cassiel instructs in the nature of *geometry*. This word literally means “measure the earth.” Geometric shapes have their origin in nature, and these, by analysis, came to be understood by mathematics. This process explains the Hermetic aphorism, “analyze and synthesize.” That is, learn to take things apart, and put them together again in useful ways. By a series of demonstrations, Cassiel reveals fundamental processes of geometry which provide insights not only into science and nature, but the also of religion and folklore.



Sachiel’s province is the “mystery of numbers.” You may think it strange to refer to numbers as mysterious. But an exploration of the mystical character of numbers is not a descent into the superstition of numerology. What the ancients believed about numbers is important for us to understand if we are to understand them. For us, at least, the mystical nature of numbers reveals the hand of God in the affairs of men. The Holy Bible, for example, tells us that a man shall leave his father and his mother and cleave unto his wife, and that they twain shall be one flesh. This may be seen as an example where two are mystically one.

Pythagoras knew that numbers describe reality. He was also aware of the mystical properties of numbers. In both cases, numbers required symbols through which they could be expressed. Many often confuse the meaning of the words “number” and “numeral.” The number itself is the abstract concept and the numeral is the symbol of that concept. A similar analogy is the use of a drawing of the heart to represent love. Love is the abstract concept and the figure of a heart is its symbol. Likewise, the figure three is the symbol of the number.

As you know, different cultures have represented numbers with different symbols.

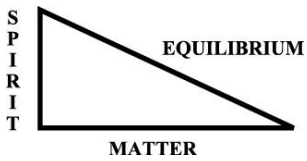
Many cultures, including the ancient Romans, Greeks, and Hebrews did not have special characters for numbers as we do. They used letters of their alphabet to express numbers. The natural result is that every word of their language had a numerical value.

The Hebrew word translated “ladder” in the story of Jacob’s Ladder has the same numerical value as the word “Sinai.” An awareness of this caused some Rabbis to say that as the angels could reach from heaven to earth by means of the “ladder,” so man could reach from earth to heaven by means of the law, delivered on Mt. Sinai.

This method of numerical equivalence is called *gematria*, whose root is the same as “geometry.” Such methods of interpretation were part of the development of an entire school in orthodox Judaism, called Kabbalah. Some numbers have a long tradition of mystical association. The number seven should readily come to mind. There are seven virtues: four cardinal and three theological, taught in Masonry. This suggests the number seven itself derives from two other numbers also having strong mystical associations; that is, the number three which permeates Freemasonry, and the number four which reminds us of the cardinal virtues and the elements of the ancients: earth, air, fire, and water.

The ancients used the number four to represent the physical world, the world we can touch, because they believed that everything in the physical world was made up of the same four elements: earth, air, fire and water. Thus the numeral became a symbol by which the physical world was represented.

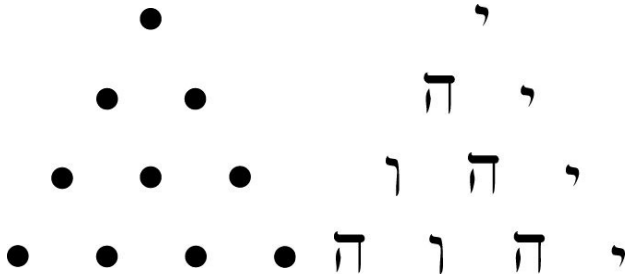
The spiritual world and God they represented by the number three, from the belief that there were three essential attributes of God. There was the intellect that desired to create, the power to create, and the actual coming forth of that creation when the Will and the Power combined. Since four represented the physical world and three the spiritual world, then seven came to represent the whole, everything that was, is and will be.



Zamael provides a synthesis of geometry and numbers. The most mystical of the ancient mathematicians was Pythagoras. The theorem which bears his name was presented by Euclid as his forty-seventh problem. From him we have adopted it as a symbol in Freemasonry. Particularly instructive is the right triangle of 3, 4, and 5 units. Its squares are composed of the simple whole numbers 9, 16, and 25.

This figure is important as a symbol in Scottish Rite Masonry because the vertical line is symbolic of spiritual things and the horizontal is symbolic of earthly, or material things. When these are formed in the right triangle the result, or hypotenuse, is symbolic of equilibrium or balance between the two.

Additional examples are provided which demonstrate that a meaningful relationship exists between numbers and shapes, and that combined, they give insights into the natural order of the universe.



Michael expounds the mystery of the Tetractys, one of the holiest symbols of the Pythagoreans. They so regarded it that they swore their oaths upon it. From this simple figure of ten points forming an equilateral triangle emerge many interesting forms, some of which will be recognized as particularly germane to Freemasonry. By medieval times the Tetractys was being used as a template for writing the tetragrammaton, the four–lettered name by which God was revealed to Moses on Mt. Sinai (yhwh, or יהוה).



Hanael instructs in religious symbolism, recalling examples of the tessera and the *ichthys* (Greek for “fish”), used by the early Christians. The *ichthys* most likely refers to Jesus as a “fisher of men.” The word *ichthys* (ΙΧΘΥΣ) also serves as an acronym of the Greek words Ἰησοῦς Χριστὸς Θεοῦ Υἱὸς Σωτήρ (*Iēsous Christos Theou Huios Sōtēr*), “Jesus Christ, Son of God, Savior.” The seal of Solomon, commonly called the star of David, is another familiar religious symbol. Its use as a symbol of Judaism is not older than the Middle Ages. It is two equilateral triangles overlapped and signifies for some the aspiration of man to reach God and the willingness of the spirit of God to descend into man.

The faith of Islam also uses the letters of its alphabet as a device for the creation of religious symbolism. The name of the prophet Mohammed, written in Arabic, is said to be the silhouette of a man kneeling in prayer. It suggests Mohammed’s submission before God, for the word “Islam” means “submission.”



Raphael’s province is the symbols of the Hermetic philosophers. These men were practitioners of the speculative and operative arts of Alchemy. The operative alchemist sought the transmutation of base metals into noble ones, such silver or gold. The speculative alchemists used the symbols of the operative craft to represent the transformation of the base man, who was represented by lead, into the perfected man, who was represented by gold. This explains the alchemical axiom, “Our gold is not the common gold.” A similar metaphor was used in the Old Testament, when God told Zechariah, that He would refine the people of Jerusalem “as silver is refined, and will try them as gold is tried.”

The Hermetic Masters said, “Make gold potable, and you will have the universal medicine.” By this they meant to say, appropriate truth to your use, let it be the spring from which you shall drink all your days, and you will have in yourselves the immortality of the sages. Temperance, tranquility of soul, simplicity of character, the calmness and reason of the will, make man not only

happy, but well and strong. It is by making himself rational and good that man makes himself immortal. We are the authors of our own destinies; and God does not save us without our cooperation.

The alchemists sought to read the symbols of the Book of Nature and so contributed many of their discoveries to the symbolism of Freemasonry. The name “Hermetic” derives from the Greek god Hermes, messenger of the gods, and the reputed founder of the arts of alchemy.

Gabriel explains that ideas may be symbolized by an entire sentence. In the Symbolic Lodge ritual we are told that there was not heard the sound of axe, hammer, or any tool of iron in the construction of King Solomon’s Temple. This part of the ritual comes from the First Book of Kings. But its meaning comes from Exodus where God ordered his altars to be built of unhewn stones because iron was a polluting metal. Here iron is seen as the enemy of the spiritual. In Egyptian mythology iron was the metal of black magic and of the evil god Set or Typhon.



Here we see an ancient hermetic illustration replete with symbols taken from the Book of Nature and since borrowed by Freemasonry. It is called the Rebis, which means ‘twice a thing’ because it represents both the male and female aspects, symbolic of equilibrium or balance. In the right hand is the square, symbolic of the material, and in the left, the compasses, symbolizing the spiritual. Around the Rebis is an arc of symbols representing the planets. The sun, over the head of the male, and the moon, over the head of the female, are there also. The figure stands upon a dragon that rests upon a winged globe. Note the point within the circle, the equilateral triangle, and the square—figures that are now familiar to you. The winged globe symbolizes eternity. An illustration as

complicated as the Rebis cannot be fully explained here and we encourage its further contemplation.

Following this presentation, Brother Truth appears, and explains that symbols both reveal and conceal. When we give an interpretation to a symbol, we hide another, deeper, meaning. As the ritual says:

> *We do not invent a dogma; we veil a truth, and a shadow is produced, to favor weak eyes. The Initiator is not an imposter, but a revealer; that is to say, according to the meaning of the Latin word revelare, one who veils anew. He is the creator of the new shadow. But by the study of symbolism we also learn that there are patterns in the fabric even deeper than the weavers know. These underlying threads which give reality its form, these deepest truths, are the handiwork and writing of the All-Wise Author of the Book of Nature.*

Brother Truth concludes by explaining that Light is an ancient symbol of truth because it reveals the world to us. For just as physical light reveals the world, spiritual light reveals the soul.

In concluding the Degree Father Adam and Brother Truth recite a catechism which explains the name “Knight of the Sun, or Prince Adept.” According to the ritual:

> *It is called “Knight of the Sun” because the Sun is the source of the material light that reveals nature to us; it is also a symbol of the Divine Light that illuminates the mind. And, it is called “Prince Adept” because those who can read the symbols of the Book of Nature are Princes among Masons, and Adepts among men.*

Near the end of the Degree we learn that

All symbols derive from the Book of Nature
and they reveal to us this great truth:
that the engines of infinity are divinely driven.

And in conclusion:

Masonic labor is to learn—and to teach others.

LECTURE

The Knight of the Sun Degree lecture in *Morals and Dogma* is the most lengthy of all, encompassing nearly one–fourth of the book. Among its concerns are the great philosophical questions which "... still, after the lapse of ages, press upon the human mind and demand solution" (p. 648). The numerous philosophical questions posited by Pike (pp. 648–649) are concerned with the Deity, the creation, the existence of good and evil, the nature of man, the soul, free will, moral law and the hereafter. To answer these questions, he gathers into this lecture a multitude of relics and fragments from the past as in the other Philosophical Degrees believing that:

Every religion was, in its origin, an embryo philosophy, or an attempt to interpret the unknown by mind; and it was only when philosophy, which is essentially progress, outgrew its first acquisitions, that religion became a thing apart, cherishing as unalterable dogmas the notions which philosophy had abandoned. ...The history of religion is the history of the human mind; and the conception formed by it of Deity is always in exact relation to its moral and intellectual attainments. The one is the index and measure of the other (pp. 650–651).

The following selections from *Morals and Dogma* are illustrative of the conclusions reached by Pike to answer the great philosophical questions and do not include the detailed information contained in the lecture. These conclusions are subsumed under one topic, the True Word of a Mason:

The True Word of a Mason is to be found in the concealed and profound meaning of the Ineffable Name of Deity, communicated by God to Moses; and which meaning was long lost by the very precautions taken to conceal it. The true pronunciation of that name was in truth a secret, in which, however, was involved the far more profound secret of its meaning. In that meaning is included

all the truth than [sic, should be "that"], can be known by us, in regard to the nature of God (p. 697).

This point is also symbolically illustrated in the ritual and the lecture. The Hebrew name for Deity, called the Tetragrammaton, is composed of four letters. The first two letters appear at the beginning of the ritual within the Seal of Solomon and the last two at the end of the lecture in *Morals and Dogma*: "All things are comprehended in the letters Vau and He; . . ." (p. 800). Thus, the entire ritual and its lecture are bracketed within the name of Deity.

The Deity and Creation:

GOD is the author of everything that existeth; the Eternal, the Supreme, the Living, and Awful Being; from Whom nothing in the Universe is hidden. Make of Him no idols and visible images; but rather worship Him in the deep solitudes of sequestered forests; for He is invisible, and fills the Universe as its soul, and liveth not in any Temple! (p. 581).

...the Ineffable Name ... embodies ... the idea of the Male and Female Principles, in its highest and most profound sense; to wit, that God originally comprehended in Himself all that is: that matter was not co–existent with Him or independent of Him; that He did not merely fashion and shape a pre–existing chaos into a Universe; but that His Thought manifested itself outwardly in that Universe, which so became, and before was not, except as comprehended in Him: that the Generative Power or Spirit, and Productive Matter, ever among the ancients deemed the Female, originally were in God; and that He Was and Is all that Was, that Is, and that Shall be: in Whom all else lives, moves, and has its being (p. 700).

The Deity and Truth:

God and truth are inseparable; a knowledge of God is possession of the saving oracles of truth. In proportion as the thought and purpose of the individual are trained to conformity with the rule of right prescribed by Supreme Intelligence, so far is his happiness promoted, and the purpose of his existence fulfilled. In

this way a new life arises in him; he is no longer isolated, but is a part of the eternal harmonies around him. His erring will is directed by the influence of a higher will, informing and moulding it in the path of his true happiness (p. 713).

Moral Truth:

Moral Truth, like every other universal and necessary truth, cannot remain a mere abstraction. Abstractions are unrealities. In ourselves, moral truth is merely conceived of. There must be somewhere a Being that not only conceives of, but constitutes it. It has this characteristic; that it is not only, to the eyes of our intelligence, an universal and necessary truth, but one obligatory on our will. It is A LAW. We do not establish that law ourselves. It is imposed on us despite ourselves: its principle must be without us. It supposes a legislator. ...As all beautiful and all true things refer themselves, these to a Unity which is absolute TRUTH, and those to a Unity which is absolute BEAUTY, so all moral principles centre in a single principle, which is THE GOOD. ...This Absolute Good must necessarily be an attribute of the Absolute BEING. There cannot be several Absolute Beings; the one in whom are realized Absolute Truth and Absolute Beauty begin different from the one in whom is realized Absolute Good. The Absolute necessarily implies absolute Unity. ...in the Being from Whom they emanate, they are indivisibly united; and this Being, at once triple and one, Who sums up in Himself perfect Beauty, perfect Truth, and the perfect Good, is GOD (pp. 702–703).

God is necessarily the principle of Moral Truth, and of personal morality. Man is a moral person, that is to say, one endowed with reason and liberty. He is capable of Virtue: and Virtue has with him two principal forms, respect for others and love of others,—justice and charity. The creature can possess no real and essential attribute which the Creator does not possess. The effect can draw its reality and existence only from its cause. The cause contains in itself, at least, what is essential in the effect. The characteristic of the effect is inferiority, short–coming, imperfection. Dependent and derivate, it bears in itself the marks and

conditions of dependence; and its imperfection proves the perfection of the cause; ... (p. 703).

Nature:

Nature is full of religious lessons to a thoughtful man. He dissolves the matter of the Universe, leaving only its forces; he dissolves away the phenomena of human history, leaving only immortal spirit; he studies the law, the mode of action of these forces and this spirit, which make up the material and the human world, and cannot fail to be filled with reverence, with trust, with boundless love of the Infinite God, who devised these laws of matter and of mind, and thereby bears up this marvellous Universe of things and men (p. 714).

Beautifully, above the great wide chaos of human errors, shines the calm, clear light of natural human religion, revealing to us God as the Infinite Parent of all, perfectly powerful, wise, just, loving, and perfectly holy too. Beautiful around stretches off every way the Universe, the Great Bible of God. Material nature is its Old Testament, millions of years old, thick with eternal truths under our feet, glittering with everlasting glories over our heads; and Human Nature is the New Testament from the Infinite God, every day revealing a new page as Time turns over the leaves (p. 715).

Everything is a thought of the Infinite God. Nature is His prose, and man His Poetry. There is no Chance, no Fate; but God's Great Providence, enfolding the whole Universe in its bosom, and feeding it with everlasting life (pp. 714–716).

Morality and Religion:

Morality is the recognition of duty, as duty, and its accomplishment, whatever the consequences. Religion is the recognition of duty in its necessary harmony with goodness; a harmony that must have its realization in another life, through the justice and omnipotence of God. Religion is as true as morality; for once morality is admitted, its consequences must be admitted. The whole moral existence is included in these two words, harmonious with each other: DUTY and HOPE (p. 717).

Knowledge is Moral and Religious:

We have long experienced that knowledge is profitable, we are beginning to find out that it is moral, and we shall at last discover it to be religious (p. 713).

Spirituality, the Soul and Immortality:

The body is composed of parts. It diminishes or increases, it is divisible even to infinity. But this something which has a consciousness of itself, and says I, ME; that feels itself free and responsible, feels I too that it is incapable of division, that it is a being one and simple; that the ME cannot be halved, ... This identity, indivisibility, and an absolute unity of the person, are its spirituality, the very essence of the person. ... By the soul we mean the person, not separated from the consciousness of the attributes which constitute it,—thought and will. The Existence without consciousness is an abstract being, and not a person. It is the person that is identical, one, simple. Its attributes, developing it, do not divide it (p. 706).

The spirituality of the soul is the condition and necessary foundation of immortality: the law of merit and demerit and direct demonstration of it. The first is the metaphysical, the second the moral proof. Add to these the tendency of all the powers of the soul toward the Infinite, and the principle of final causes, and the proof of the immortality of the soul is complete (p. 706).

Free Will:

Obligation is founded on the necessary distinction between the good and the evil; and it is itself the foundation of liberty. If man has his duties to perform, he must have the faculty of accomplishing them, of resisting desire, passion, and interest, in order to obey the law. He must be free; therefore he is so, or human nature is in contradiction with itself. The certainty of the obligation involves the corresponding certainty of free will (p. 723).

It is the will that is free: though sometimes that will may be ineffectual. The power to do must not be confounded with the power to will. The former may be

limited: the latter is sovereign. The external effects may be prevented: the resolution itself cannot. Of this sovereign power of the will we are conscious. ...At the same time when I will this or that, I am equally conscious that I can will the contrary. I am conscious that 1 am the master of my resolution: that I may check it, continue it, retake it. ... Wherefore free–will is the essential and ever–subsisting attribute of the will itself (p. 723).

Existence of Good and Evil:

In times past there has been evil which we cannot understand; now there are evils which we cannot solve, nor make square with God's perfect goodness by any theory our feeble intellect enables us to frame. There are sufferings, follies, and sins for all mankind, for every nation, for every man and every woman. They were all foreseen by the infinite wisdom of God, all provided for by His infinite power and justice, and all are consistent with His infinite love (p. 716).

The end of man and the object of existence in this world, being not only happiness, but happiness in virtue and through virtue, virtue in this world is the condition of happiness in another life, and the condition of virtue in this world is suffering, more or less frequent, briefer or longer continued, more or less intense. Take away suffering, and there is no longer any resignation or humanity, no more self–sacrifice, no more devotedness, no more heroic virtues, no more sublime morality (p. 716).

The Moral Code and Philosophy of Masonry:

Human wisdom must always be limited and incorrect; and even right opinion is only a something intermediate between ignorance and knowledge. The normal condition of man is that of progress. Philosophy is a kind of journey, ever learning, yet never arriving at the ideal perfection of truth. A Mason should, like the wise Socrates, assume the modest title of a lover of wisdom; for he must ever long after something more excellent than he possesses, something still beyond his reach, which he desires to make eternally his own (p. 691).

The Moral Code of Masonry is still more extensive than that developed by philosophy. To the requisitions of the law of Nature and the law of God, it adds the imperative obligation of a contract. Upon entering the Order, the Initiate binds to himself every Mason in the world. Once enrolled among the children of Light, every Mason on earth becomes his brother, and owes him the duties, the kindnesses, and the sympathies of a brother. ... What so many thousands owe to him, he owes to each of them. He has solemnly bound himself to be ever ready to discharge this sacred debt. If he fails to do it he is dishonest and forsworn; and it is an unparalleled meanness in him to obtain good offices by false pretences, to receive kindness and service, rendered him under the confident expectation that he will in his turn render the same, and then to disappoint, without ample reason, that just expectation (p. 726).